



FOOTPRINTS WITHOUT FEET

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: H. G. Wells

About the Author:

H. G. Wells (Herbert George Wells, 1866-1946) was a famous English writer known as one of the fathers of science fiction. His works often combine scientific imagination with social criticism and human behaviour. In “**Footprints Without Feet**”, adapted from his novel *The Invisible Man*, Wells shows how scientific discovery becomes dangerous when it is controlled by anger, selfishness, and lack of moral responsibility.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The misuse of science when intelligence is not guided by morality.
- Invisible power becoming dangerous in the hands of a selfish person.
- Crime, anger, and revenge as signs of moral weakness.
- The difference between scientific success and human responsibility.
- How fear and mystery are created when truth is hidden from ordinary people.

Values:

- Knowledge must be used responsibly, not for selfishness or crime.
- Anger and revenge destroy dignity and make a person dangerous.
- Power without self-control becomes a threat to society.
- Honesty, patience, and discipline matter more than cleverness alone.
- Science should help humanity, not create fear, violence, or disorder.

2. Characters

- **Griffin:** A brilliant but lawless scientist who discovers how to become invisible. He is intelligent, but his anger, selfishness, and criminal behaviour make him dangerous.
- **Mrs. Hall:** The owner of the inn at Iping. She is practical and curious. She tries to serve Griffin politely but becomes suspicious of his strange behaviour.
- **Mr. Hall:** Mrs. Hall's husband, who also becomes doubtful about Griffin and gets involved when the strange events at the inn become serious.
- **The Clergyman:** A respectable man from whose house money is stolen by Griffin while he remains invisible.
- **Jaffers:** The village constable who tries to arrest Griffin but fails because Griffin removes his clothes and becomes invisible again.
- **The Shopkeepers and Villagers:** Ordinary people who witness strange events and become frightened by the mystery of the invisible man.

3. Detailed Summary

“**Footprints Without Feet**” is a science-fiction story about **Griffin**, a brilliant scientist who discovers how to make the human body invisible. His discovery is great, but his character is weak. Instead of using science for good, he uses invisibility for revenge, theft, escape, and violence.

The story opens with two boys seeing fresh footprints appear in the mud without any visible person. The mystery is created because Griffin is walking

there invisibly; only the marks of his feet can be seen. The title itself comes from this strange sight.

Earlier, Griffin had succeeded in making himself invisible. But when his landlord tried to remove him, Griffin became angry, set fire to the house, and ran away. This shows that he has scientific intelligence but no discipline, patience, or moral control.

Invisibility creates practical problems for Griffin. His body cannot be seen, but his clothes can be seen, so he has to remove them to stay fully invisible. Wandering without clothes in the cold streets of London, he becomes hungry, tired, and desperate.

To survive, he enters a large store after closing time. He eats food, wears warm clothes, and sleeps comfortably for the night. But when the store assistants arrive in the morning, he is almost caught. He removes his clothes again, becomes invisible, and escapes.

Next, Griffin enters a theatrical company's shop, where he finds costumes, wigs, bandages, glasses, and false features. These help him create a visible disguise. He also attacks the shopkeeper and steals money, proving again that he is ready to harm others for his own safety.

Disguised with bandages and dark glasses, Griffin reaches the village of **Iping** and stays at an inn owned by **Mrs. Hall**. His strange appearance, rude behaviour, and demand for privacy make people curious and suspicious. Mrs. Hall remains polite at first because he is a paying guest.

Soon, a robbery takes place at the clergyman's house. Money is stolen, but no one can see the thief. Around the same time, Griffin suddenly has money to pay his bills, though earlier he had no ready cash. This increases the suspicion against him.

Strange events also occur at the inn: furniture seems to move by itself, doors open and close mysteriously, and people feel the presence of an unseen force. The villagers become frightened because they are facing something beyond normal experience.

When Mrs. Hall questions Griffin, he loses his temper and removes his bandages, glasses, and false features. The people are shocked to see clothes without a visible head or body. His secret is exposed: he is an invisible man.

The constable **Jaffers** comes to arrest him, but Griffin removes his clothes piece by piece and becomes completely invisible again. In the confusion, he attacks people and escapes. His discovery helps him avoid the law, but it also proves how dangerous he has become.

The chapter teaches that intelligence alone is not greatness. Griffin is a successful scientist, but he fails as a human being. Science becomes harmful when it is controlled by anger, selfishness, and lack of responsibility.

4. Key Points

- **Griffin** discovers how to make himself invisible, but he uses the discovery wrongly.
- He burns his landlord's house in anger and escapes unseen.
- He enters a store for food, clothes, and shelter, but must escape when workers arrive.
- He steals from a theatrical shop and uses costumes and bandages to create a visible disguise.
- At **Iping**, his strange behaviour and sudden money make people suspicious.
- The theft at the clergyman's house and the strange events at the inn reveal the danger around him.
- **Jaffers** tries to arrest him, but Griffin becomes invisible again and escapes.

5. Moral

- Science is powerful, but it must be controlled by morality and responsibility.
- Intelligence without character can become dangerous.
- Power used for selfishness leads to crime, fear, and social harm.

- Anger and revenge can turn a talented person into a destructive person.
- No one can truly escape the results of wrong actions; even hidden crimes leave signs behind.
- A great discovery becomes useful only when it serves people, not when it threatens them.

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